By the evening, the GEC, tasked only to report to Mistry, and which had a crucial role in determining the strategic direction of the group and the individual companies, was also disbanded. Mistry's removal, 'in some ways', was the 'most painful and difficult thing' for Ratan, Nohria says. Srinivasan adds that 'it was a very hard decision for Ratan to take; I think it took a lot out of him', because he had to 'stand in many ways for things that he does not stand for'. He says Ratan 'suffered more than Cyrus in a way; people may not quite understand or accept it and for Cyrus it's certainly something he would not accept or believe but the truth is I think he took a lot of suffering, on that score'.

Nohria opines that to his mind, what was 'very damaging to Mr Tata' was the 'speculation that somehow he was determined from the first, [and] was reluctant in moving out and once he moved out, he wanted to be still engaged, that's why he meddled with Mr Mistry'. Commenting on the accusation that Ratan was 'determined to undermine Mr Mistry', Nohria says that 'I find [this to be] preposterous because of the way he even invited me' to be on the board of Tata Sons, to help Mistry succeed, was the incontrovertible evidence that Ratan was willing to do anything to make Mistry succeed. Srinivasan airs a similar opinion when he says that Ratan wanted Mistry to succeed but was finally compelled to do what 'he would not have liked to do'. He adds that like the US President Ronald Reagan, 'Riding off into the sunset' was what Ratan would have liked to do after he stepped down as group chairman.

Not until Mistry's removal had the empire that Jamsetji built found itself embroiled in an escalating crisis of this magnitude. The events that followed were unprecedented. It would hurt the zealously and painstakingly guarded reputation of Tata House and suck Ratan into a slinging match of allegations and counter-allegations.

A Twist to the Tale

Two theories have made the rounds as to why Mistry ran down his predecessor, kept Tata Trusts and its chairman in the dark on important issues, denied directors in Tata Sons representations on the boards of large companies and instead chose to be on them himself more than what his predecessors did. The first is that Mistry was determinedly working to dismantle Ratan's legacy. His decision to sell Tata Steel UK and the